

CHAPTER ONE

Indigenous Education in India at the Beginning of the Nineteenth Century

Introductory: The principal object of this book is to trace the growth of the modern system of education which came to be established in India during the British Period in supersession of the traditional indigenous system of education which had developed in the country through centuries past. It is a common belief, particularly among many Western scholars, that this indigenous system of education had hardly anything of value in it; that it was better dead than alive; and that the British officers of the Education Department were fully justified in allowing or even helping it to die and in replacing it by the modern system of schools, colleges and universities. It is an essential part of the work of those who undertake to write the history of education in India to find out whether, and if so, how far such a belief is justified. We, therefore, propose to discuss, in this initial chapter, the character and extent of the indigenous system of education as it prevailed in India at the beginning of the nineteenth century (when the British Government may be said to have begun laying the foundation of the modern system of education), its merits and demerits and its potentialities to develop into a national system of education by suitable improvement and extension.

It must be remembered that the Indian society at the end of the eighteenth century was essentially a feudal society consisting of several classes and a very large number of castes and tribes. The princely governments of the day had not accepted any responsibility for the education of the people and all their educational effort was limited to the provision of some financial support to learned persons and institutions of higher learning, mainly on religious considerations. The society itself had little use for a

formal system of education. Priestly classes who formed a very small minority needed formal institutions for religious instruction and therefore created and maintained them through their own efforts, with such support from the princes and the people as they could muster. The small class of government servants, merchants, money-lenders and the more well-to-do landlords also did need some elementary education in three R's and they organised for themselves the institutions needed for the purpose. These could also be availed of by others if they so desired. The bulk of the population, however, never went to formal educational institutions. The principal means of their education were non-formal. What they needed most was vocational education and they generally obtained it by working at the family occupation. The women, as a rule, never went to schools. They learnt the art of home making, child rearing and participating (where necessary) in the family occupation, through an apprenticeship to their mothers and other elderly women in the family. The absence of a formal system of education for the vast majority of the people has often led foreigners to regard the Indian people of the day as ignorant and uncultured. This is totally incorrect. The absence of the formal system of education or his illiteracy did not prevent the average Indian from absorbing his traditional culture through non-formal agencies at home and in society; and sympathetic observers of this period who came in close contact with the people did not fail to notice their vocational skills of very high order, their basic human qualities and their fascinating and lovable culture. What we will be discussing in this chapter, however, is not the non-formal methods of instruction at home and in society which trained every person in this vocation, initiate him in the traditional culture and socialised him as a useful and responsible member of his family and the community, but the formal system of education, elementary and higher, which was meant for a small sector of the society which needed it and which was availed of mostly by men. It is necessary to remember this deliberately limited scope of our discussion so that one does not assume that the small formal process of education was all the education the people received and ignore the existence and significance of the vastly greater processes of non-formal education which were current in this society and which were really responsi-

ble for giving the most worthwhile education to the vast majority of the people.

Sources of Information: It is unfortunate that the sources of information regarding the character and extent of the indigenous system of education in the earlier half of the nineteenth century should be extremely meagre. In the first place, the available sources refer only to British territories which, at that time, formed but a small part of India, and we have next to no data regarding the vast remaining area which was under the rule of several Indian potentates. Secondly, our sources do not cover even the whole of that area which was then under British rule. In Madras, an inquiry into indigenous education was ordered by Sir Thomas Munro in 1822 and the information obtained refers to all districts except that of Kanara. In Bombay, a similar enquiry was ordered by Mountstuart Elphinstone in 1823 and statistics were obtained through the Collectors for most of the Province while, in 1829, similar statistics for the Province as a whole were collected through the Judicial Department. In Bengal, a special enquiry into indigenous education was conducted in 1835-38, under the orders of Lord William Bentinck, by William Adam—a missionary who had devoted himself to the cause of Indian education. Adam submitted three reports of which the first is a digest of the earlier reports on the subject, the second is a thorough enquiry of one Thana in the district of Rajshahi and the third gives statistics of five districts in Bengal and Bihar out of a total of nineteen. It will thus be seen that any conclusions regarding the indigenous system of education in India, as a whole, must be based on the assumption that the area covered by the three enquiries referred to above is a fair sample of the whole countryside. Such an assumption is obviously not very sound from the statistical point of view; but it becomes inevitable in the absence of any other data.

What handicaps a student of history, however, is not so much the inadequacy of the area covered by these enquiries as their defects from the statistical or other points of view. The enquiries in Madras and Bombay were most unsatisfactory in so far as accuracy and thoroughness are concerned and it will be shown later that they included neither all the schools in existence nor all the pupils under instruction. Adam's enquiries, on the other

hand, were thorough and almost flawless. But they were conducted in a Province which had been subjected to general anarchy for a very long time and where the system of indigenous education, as Adam himself pointed out, was everywhere in a state of decay. **The conclusions of Adam, therefore, are not quite applicable to those parts of India which had the good fortune to enjoy a more or less settled Government.** These defects in the investigation will, therefore, have to be duly allowed for in forming a fair picture of the indigenous system of education as it existed at the beginning of the nineteenth century.

The Enquiry in Madras: The first of the three enquiries mentioned above was that undertaken by **Sir Thomas Munro in Madras.** Its results were thus summed up by Munro himself:

The Board of Revenue were directed by Government on the 2nd July, 1822, to ascertain the number of schools, and the state of education among the natives in the provinces, and with their letter of the 21st February last, they transmitted the reports on this subject which they had received from the several collectors. From these reports it appears that the number of schools, and **what are called colleges, in the territories under this Presidency, amounts to 12,498, and the population to 12,850,941; so that there is one school to every 1,000 of the population;** but as only a very few females are taught in school, **we may reckon one school to every 500 of the population.**

2. It is remarked by the Board of Revenue, that of a population of **12½ millions there are only 188,000 or 1 in 67 receiving education.** This is true of the whole population, but not as regards the male part of it, of which the proportion educated is much greater than is here estimated; for if we take the whole population as stated in the report at 1,285,000 and deduct one-half for females, the remaining male population will be 6,425,000; and if we reckon the **male population between the age of five and ten years, which is the period which boys in general remain at school, at one-ninth,** it will give 713,000 which is the number of boys that would be at school if all the males above ten years of age were educated; but the number actually-attending the school is only 184,110, or little more than one-fourth of that number. I

have taken the interval between five and ten years of age as the term of education, because, though many boys continue at school till twelve or fourteen, many leave it under ten. **I am, however, inclined to estimate the portion of the male population who receive school education to be nearer to one-third than one-fourth of the whole, because we have no returns from the provinces of the number taught at home.**¹ In Madras² the number taught at home is 26,903, or **above five times greater than that taught in the schools.** There is probably some error in this number, and though the number privately taught in the provinces does certainly not approach this rate, it is no doubt considerable because the practice of boys being taught at home by their relations or private teachers is not infrequent in any part of the country. The proportion educated is very different in different classes; in some it is nearly the whole; in others it is hardly one-tenth.

3. **The state of education here exhibited, low as it is compared with that of our own country, is higher than it was in most European countries at no very distant period.**¹ It has, no doubt, been better in earlier times.³

Report of the Collector of Bellary: Of the reports of the Collectors, the most interesting is that of the Collector of Bellary. It deserves to be quoted in extenso for the following graphic picture of the elementary indigenous schools of those days.

6. The education of the Hindoo youths generally commences when they are five years old; on reaching this age, the master and scholars of the school to which the boy is to be sent, are invited **to the house of his parents, the whole are seated in a circle round an image of Gunasee and the child to be initiated is placed exactly opposite to it.** The schoolmaster sitting by his side, after having burnt incense and presented offerings, causes the child to repeat a prayer to Gunasee, entreating wisdom. **He then guides the child to write with its finger in rice the mystic name of the deity,** and is dismissed with a present from the parents according to their ability. The child next morning commences the great work of his

¹ Italics ours.

² The word 'Madras' refers to the City of Madras and not to the Province of Madras. Vide Sir Philip Hartog: *Some Aspects of Indian Education*, p. 72.

³ *Selections from the Records of the Government of Madras*, No. II, Appendix E.

education.

7. Some children continue at school only five years; the parents, through poverty or other circumstances, being often obliged to take them away; and consequently in such cases the merest smattering of an education is obtained; where parents can afford it, and take a lively interest in the culture of their children's mind, they not infrequently continue at school as long as 14 or 15 years.

8. The internal routine of duty for each day will be found, with very few exceptions and little variation, the same in all the schools. The hour generally for opening school is six o'clock, the first child that enters has the name of Saraswatee, or the goddess of learning, written upon the palm of his hand as a sign of honour; and on the hand of the second a cypher is written to show that he is worthy neither of praise nor censure; the third scholar receives a gentle stripe; the fourth two; and every succeeding scholar that comes an additional one. The custom, as well as the punishment in native schools, seems of a severe kind. The idle scholar is flogged  often suspended by both hands and a pulley to the roof, or obliged to kneel down and rise incessantly, which is a most painful and fatiguing, but perhaps a healthy mode of punishment.

9. When the whole are assembled, the scholars, according to their number and attainments, are divided into several classes, the lower ones of which are partly under the c of monitors, whilst the higher ones are more immediately under the superintendence of the master, who at the same time has his eye upon the whole school. The number of classes is generally four, and a scholar rises from one to the other according to his capacity and progress. The first business of a child on entering school is to obtain a knowledge of the letters, which he learns by writing them with his finger on the ground in sand, and not by pronouncing the alphabet, as among European nations. When he becomes pretty dexterous in writing with his finger in sand, he has then the privilege of writing either with an iron style on cadjan leaves, or with a reed on paper, and sometimes on the ves of the *Aristolochia Indica*, or with a kind of pencil on the Hulligi or Kadala, which answers the purpose of slates. The two latter in these districts are the most common. One of these is a common

oblong board, about a foot in width and three feet in length; this board when planed smooth has only to be smeared with a little rice and pulverized charcoal, and it is then fit for use. The other is made of cloth first stiffened with rice water, doubled into folds resembling a book, and it is then covered with a composition of charcoal and several gums. The writing on either of these may be effaced by a wet cloth the pencil used is called Bultapa, a kind of white clay substance, somewhat resembling a crayon, with the exception of being rather harder.

10. Having attained a thorough knowledge of the letters, the scholar next learns to write the compounds, or the manner of embodying the symbols of the vowels in the consonants and the formation of syllables, etc., then the names of men, villages, animals, etc., and lastly arithmetical signs. He then commits to memory an addition table and counts from one to 100; he afterwards writes easy sums in addition and subtraction of money, multiplication and the reduction of money, measure, etc. Here great pains are taken with the scholar in teaching him the fractions of an integer, which descend, not by tens as in our decimal fractions, but by fours, and a arried to a great extent. In order that these fractions together with the arithmetical tables in addition, multiplication and the three-fold measures of capacity, weight and extent, may be rendered quite familiar to the minds of the scholars, they are made to stand up twice a day in rows, and repeat the whole after one of the monitors.

11. The other parts of native education consist in deciphering various kinds of handwriting in public, and other letters which the schoolmaster collects from different sources, writing common letters, drawing up forms of agreement, reading fables and legendary tales and committing various kinds of poetry to memory, chiefly with a view to attain distinctness and clearness of pronunciation together with readiness and correctness in reading any kind of composition.

16. The economy with which children are taught to write in the native schools, and the system by which the most advanced scholars are caused to teach the less advanced, and at the same time to confirm their own knowledge, - is certainly admirable, and well deserves the imitation it has received in England. The chief defects in the native schools are the nature of the books and learning

taught and the want of competent masters.¹

Reliability of the Enquiry in Madras : The reliability of the statistics obtained from this enquiry is generally challenged by historians on grounds that are diametrically opposed to each other. One view represented by Sir Philip Hartog holds that these statistics were overestimated.² A closer examination of the available data will, however, show that this view is not correct. In the first place, the statistics for children under domestic instruction were excluded (except for the District of Madras) in the figures given by the Collectors. It must be remembered that Munro's original circular did not refer to domestic instruction.³ Very possibly, Munro was unaware of its existence at that time. It would be obvious to anyone who is conversant with official routine that the Collectors did not supply the figures of children under domestic instruction, not because it did not exist in their district, not even because they were unaware of its existence, but because the figures were not explicitly called for in Government orders. This is clear from the fact that no Collector except that of Madras gave statistics of children under domestic instruction although Munro was convinced that "the practice of boys being taught at home by their parents or private teachers is not infrequent in any part of the country". The Collector of Madras apparently went out of his way and supplied the figures of pupils under domestic instruction also, even though they were not specially called for. It is certainly an ill reward for all this labour to class him with Collectors "less careful and interested in education than Campbell" as Sir Philip seems to do.

Secondly, it must be noted that Munro himself was convinced that his statistics were underestimates. He calculated the population of school-going age at 1/9th of the total population. This gave him the number of boys of school-going age at 713,000 and he found that only 184,000 or one-fourth were in schools. But he felt that some allowance must be made for the children under

¹ *Selections from the Record of the Government of Madras*, No. II, Appendix D. (Italics ours.)

² Sir Philip Hartog : *Some Aspects of Indian Education*, p. 72.

³ *Selections from the Records of the Government of Madras*, No. II, Appendix A.

domestic instruction. He was not prepared to accept the figures given by the Collector of Madras as reliable because he could not believe that for every boy in a school there were five under domestic instruction. But all the same, he admitted that the figures available were underestimates and observed, that the number of boys under instruction was nearer to one-third than to one-fourth of the total number of boys of school-going age.

Perhaps the best course for Munro would have been to demand a rechecking of the Madras figures and to collect statistics of children under domestic instruction from other Collectors. But he was not interested in the problem. He did not aim at statistical accuracy. His only object, as he pointed out in his original Minute, was to have some idea of the indigenous system and he dropped all further enquiry in the matter as he felt that he had enough data to prepare his proposals for educational reform. It would be futile to speculate as to what would have been the result of a careful enquiry into the system of domestic instruction, but there can be no doubt that the available evidence clearly points to the conclusion that Munro's figures were largely underestimated.

The Enquiries in Bombay (1823-25): Shortly after Munro had started his enquiry into indigenous education in the Province of Madras, Mountstuart Elphinstone, the Governor of Bombay, started a similar enquiry in the Province of Bombay. At his instance, the Secretary to Government addressed a circular letter to all Collectors (dated 10th March 1824) and called for immediate information regarding indigenous education. The replies from most of the Collectors were received in 1824-25 and have been recently published with an erudite editorial note, by Shri R. V. Parulekar.¹ These reports do not cover the whole of the Province as it then existed; nor can all relevant papers of the enquiry be traced at present. But from such data as is available, the following general conclusions may be drawn about the then condition of indigenous education in the Province of Bombay:

(a) **The Elementary Indigenous Schools:** There is no mention of a single school which was held in a house exclusively used for

¹ *A Source-Book of History of Education in the Bombay Province*, Part I, Survey of Indigenous Education (1820-30).

itself. Most of them were held in temples, private dwellings or sheds, or the houses of the teachers themselves. In some cases, a respectable gentleman in the town or village gave a portion of his house for holding a school. They had hardly any continuity and sprang up or vanished according to local demand or its absence. The average number of pupils per school worked out at 15 and varied from 2 to 150, and most of the schools were single-teacher institutions. As a rule, they were not communal in their working and were open to all who could afford to pay for their schooling except to those who belonged to the so-called low castes.

(b) *The Teachers:* Of the teachers, the majority were Brahmins who were attached to the profession more by the respectability which tradition gave to it rather than by considerations of actual gains in cash or kind. Among the other castes from which teachers generally came may be mentioned the names of Prabhus, Marathas, Bhandarees, Kunbis, Wanis, Shimpis, Baniyas, etc. The total remuneration of the teacher was between Rs. 3 and Rs. 5 p.m. on an average and consisted of payments in cash and kind. But there were some compensations for this low remuneration. As Shri R. V. Parulekar observes:

We have so far considered the regular emoluments which the schoolmasters expected to get as their dues. In actual practice, however, they scarcely got the full amount. The schoolmaster of the time, however, could claim certain privileges from the community which compensated, not to a small extent, for the smallness of his earning. He was entirely a man of the people whose children he taught. He was always remembered in the hearts and at the hearths of the people. The well-to-do and the rich gave him more than others, both in cash and kind. He could command a meal from the parents of his pupils for mere asking. On marriage ceremonies of his pupils—and these were not rare in those days of polygamy—he received substantial presents and gave his blessings. The Ahmedabad report says 'A schoolmaster is invariably invited to all great dinners in his own caste and besides his fixed and established emoluments he generally receives considerable presents at Dusserah, Dewally and other great days, from the wealthy inhabitants of his village. It is

usual when a marriage procession passes by a school, to make a small present in money to the schoolmaster, and to obtain a holiday, for the boys. From the Karnatak, a similar practice is also reported where the teacher was remembered with equal love and respect on occasions of joy and festivity.¹

The educational attainments of the teachers were also far from satisfactory. As Shri R. V. Parulekar points out,

The teachers who taught in the common elementary schools of the time were required to teach the rudiments of the three R's. Knowledge of the multiplication and other tables in their long and complicated array was essential to every teacher; but beyond that a tolerably good handwriting and ability to read simple writing formed the minimum attainments of a common schoolmaster. It is not, therefore, surprising that a report from Gujraṭh says 'the masters are ignorant, and in fact, as to knowledge to be gained from books, have as much to learn as the boys themselves'.²

(c) *The Pupils* of the elementary schools came from all Hindu castes, except the Harijans. About 30 per cent of them were Brahmins. The other castes which sent large numbers of pupils to schools were Wanis, Prabhus, Sonars and Baniyas. The advanced communities contributed about 70 per cent of the total number of pupils. Their age varied from 6 to 14; and the average duration of school life was about 2 or 3 years in Gujarat and about 3 or 4 years in the other areas.

(d) *Curriculum and Methods of Teaching:* The elementary schools taught the rudiments of Reading, Writing and Arithmetic. A large variety of multiplication tables were taught to the pupils mainly with a view to enabling them to solve mentally all types of sums that ordinarily occurred in daily life. There was a complete absence of printed books. The equipment of the schools was very simple and crude, if it existed at all, and the punishments awarded to pupils were both frequent and severe.

(e) *Female Education:* There is no mention of a female scholar

¹ R. V. Parulekar : *op.cit.*, p. ix.

² *Ibid.*

attending any of the common schools of the Province. This is by no means due to hurry or omission. The common schools of the time were meant for boys only.

(f) *Domestic Instruction*: The Bombay reports do not take into consideration the system of domestic instruction and do not give any details about the system, although they contain some stray references to its existence in different parts of the Province.

(g) *Education of the Muslims*: There were several indigenous schools which were attended by Muslims alone and which were in charge of Muslim teachers. These schools taught Persian and, in some cases, *Hindustani*. In several places, Muslims attended the ordinary Hindu schools.

(h) *Hindu Schools of Higher Learning*: Some of the reports mention the Hindu Schools of higher learning. In Ahmednagar 16 such schools existed and in Poona City, there were as many as 164 (out of a total of 222 educational institutions of all kinds).

The Enquiry in Bombay (1829): This enquiry was different from those of 1823—25 because the information was now called for, not through the Collectors, but through the District Judges. It showed the existence of 1,705 schools with 35,153 pupils for a population of 4,681,735.

Reliability of the Enquiries in Bombay: How far are these reports reliable? From the qualitative point of view, it may be admitted that they give a fairly correct picture of the indigenous educational institutions of the period. But it may well be doubted whether they give an equally realistic picture on the quantitative side. It has already been stated, that these reports do not take much notice of the system of domestic instruction which certainly existed in Bombay. Even in respect of formal schools, it is highly improbable that they include statistics of all the institutions in existence. Several of these reports were compiled in great haste. For instance, the Broach, Kaira and Surat Collectors were able to submit their reports within about four months of the Government letter instituting the enquiry. Although others were not so expeditious, the time taken by them was not certainly enough for such an extensive enquiry touching every village in the districts reported upon, especially in view of the slow means of conveyance

and despatch of correspondence which then prevailed. The 1828-29 report was also not more cautious in this respect. Secondly, errors seem to have crept in because of the peculiar situation of this period. "The Peshwa's rule was just ended and the New Rulers were just establishing theirs. There was an atmosphere of suspicion that whatever Government did was with some ulterior motive for its own benefit."¹ In such an atmosphere, it is hardly to be wondered if the people deliberately suppressed information regarding several schools from the enquiring officers of the Government. Thirdly, the reports were mostly compiled by busy officers who were not particularly interested in the problems and anyone who is conversant with such official enquiries knows that their results are not always reliable. Fourthly, evidence to the contrary is available from the statements of several important British officials of this period. As Shri R. V. Parulekar observes:

The following remarkable statement was made by Mr. G. L. Prendergast, a member of the Bombay Governor's Council in his Minute of 1821:

I need hardly mention what every member of the Board knows as well as I do, that there is hardly a village, great or small, throughout our territories, in which there is not at least one school, and in larger villages more, many in every town and in larger cities in every division; where young natives are taught reading, writing and arithmetic, upon a system so economical, from a handful or two of grain, to perhaps a rupee per month to the schoolmaster; according to the ability of the parents, and at the same time so simple and effectual that there is hardly a cultivator or petty dealer who is not competent to keep his own accounts with a degree of accuracy, in my opinion, beyond what we meet with amongst the lower orders in our own country; while the more splendid dealer, and bankers keep their books with a degree of ease, conciseness and clearness, I rather think fully equal to those of any British Merchant (Evidence of 1832, p. 468).

There are schools maintained by the natives in almost every village in Candeish (Evidence of 1832, p. 296).

¹ R. V. Parulekar : *op. cit.*, p. iv.

There is probably as great a proportion of persons in India who can read, write and keep simple accounts as are to be found in European Countries [Fifth Annual Report (1819) of the Bombay Education Society, p. 11].

Schools are frequent among the natives and abound everywhere [B. E. S.'s sixth Report (1820), p. 21].

We do not suggest that these general impressions about the extent of education in the Province of Bombay should be taken at their face value, but to ignore them altogether and to insist on taking the 'official' figures at their face value would be equally improper.¹

An approach to the problem with an open mind is, therefore, more likely to show that the Bombay statistics are unreliable underestimates than to prove that they can be taken as the yardstick with which to measure the extent of elementary education in India as a whole.

Enquiries in Bengal: The enquiries conducted in Bengal regarding the indigenous system of education differed strikingly from those in Madras and Bombay. These enquiries were conducted by a non-official—a zealous missionary by the name of William Adam—and not through the official channels of the Revenue and Judicial Departments. Moreover, the work of these enquiries was far more methodical and spread over a far longer time than was the case with those in Madras and Bombay. The findings of William Adam, therefore, deserve a very careful study.²

(a) *Adam's First Report:* The first report of Adam is a very carefully prepared digest of all the educational data then available. It makes very good reading although the information it contains is neither so adequate nor so reliable as that in his own two later reports. The main interest of the report lies, however, in the following passage which, in recent years, has become the subject of a great controversy:

Indigenous Elementary Schools: By this description are meant

¹ R. V. Parulekar : *op. cit.*, p. v.

² The information given in this and the following paragraphs is taken from the edition of *Adam's Reports* edited by Shri A.M. Basu and published by the University of Calcutta.

those schools in which instruction in the elements of knowledge is communicated, and which have been originated and are supported by the Natives themselves, in contra-distinction from those that are supported by religious or philanthropic societies. The number of such schools in Bengal is supposed to be very great. A distinguished member of the General Committee of Public Instruction in a minute on the subject expressed the opinion, that if one rupee per mensem were expended on each existing village school in the Lower Provinces, the amount would probably fall little short of 12 lakhs of rupees per annum. This supposes that there are 100,000 such schools in Bengal and Bihar, and assuming the population of those two provinces to be 40,000,000, there would be a village school for every 400 persons.¹

This report has been dubbed a myth or a legend by some students of educational history (like Sir Philip Hartog) while others (like Shri R. V. Parulekar) maintain with equal force that it is substantially correct. The argument chiefly centres round two points : firstly, the two sides differ in the interpretation of the word *school*. One side uses the expression in its modern sense, viz., an institution of a more or less permanent nature conducted by a person who teaches a certain number of the children of the locality in return for fees and perquisites from the pupils and/or a remuneration from the community. If the word is used in this sense, it is correct to conclude that the idea of 100,000 schools in Bengal is a fantastic exaggeration of facts. But the other side contests this interpretation. It argues that, in those days, the word *school* was used to mean a place where instruction was given and included the centres where the system of domestic instruction prevailed. According to this view, a family where a teacher was employed to give education to its children, or where the father taught his own children—with or without other children from the locality—was also a *school* as understood in those days. In support of this theory, it is pointed out that Adam collected all statistics of families giving domestic instruction as part of his enquiry about schools and scholars.² If this view is accepted, it

¹ *Adam's Reports*—Calcutta Edition, p. 6.

² Adam's own words on this subject are the following:

"Elementary instruction in this district (*i.e.*, *Rajshahi*) is divisible into two

follows that almost every village in Bengal had a school, public or private, and that the larger ones had several each.

Secondly, the question as to why Adam himself did not point out the falsity of the *legend* of one lakh schools is also variously answered. The honesty of Adam is not doubted; but Sir Philip thinks that he could not "summarize his statistics clearly",¹ while the other side points out the great powers of observation and analysis that he displays in his reports and asserts that the legend of 100,000 schools had persisted in official and non-official circles for the simple reason that it was not a legend. As M.R. Paranjpe observed:

Officials and publicists who belong to this century and who have no personal knowledge of the educational conditions of the country in the middle half of the nineteenth century are unwilling to believe that there ever were schools in villages where the modern Departments of Education find it impossible to maintain them. They cannot conceive of simple instructional centres maintained by the villages jointly or by rich landlords individually, by paying the teachers in kind. But officials and non-officials who lived in the fifties and sixties of the last century have, like Adam, admitted the existence of a school in every village. At the beginning of the nineteenth century, there existed a fairly widespread organization for primary education in most parts of India. In Madras Presidency, Sir, Thomas Munro found 'a primary school in every village' (Mill—*History of British India*, Vol. I, p. 562, 4th edition). In Bengal, Ward discovered that 'almost all villages possessed schools for teaching reading, writing, and elementary arithmetic.' (Ward—*View of the Hindoos*, Vol. I, p. 160.) In Malva, which was for more than half a century suffering from continuous anarchy, Malcolm noticed that 'every village with about a hundred houses had an elementary school at the time of its coming under the British suzerainty.' (Malcolm—*Memoirs of Central India and Malva*, sorts : Public and Private, according as it is communicated in public schools or private families. The distinction is not always strictly maintained, but it is sufficiently marked."—*Reports*, Calcutta Edition, pp. 136-37.

¹ Sir Philip Hartog : *Some Aspects of Indian Education*, p. 75.

Vol. II, p. 150.)¹

(b) *Adam's Second Report*: In his second report, Adam made a thorough and comprehensive enquiry of one Thana, Nattore, in the district of Rajshahi. His main object in doing this was to get an insight into the problem and the difficulties of investigation. He selected Nattore because it was the most central of the Thanas of the Rajshahi district and could be regarded as a standard for judging conditions in the other sub-divisions. The results of Adam's enquiries are briefly stated in the following paragraphs.

The population of the Thana was 19, [] of which 129,640 were Muslims and 65,656 Hindus. The number of villages was 485. Adam found only 27 elementary schools with 262 pupils. Of these 10 were Bengali schools with 167 pupils, 4 were Persian schools with 23 pupils, 11 were Arabic schools (for the teaching of the Koran) with 42 pupils and 2 were Bengali and Persian schools with 30 pupils. Besides these, there were 1,588 families belonging to 238 villages, which gave instruction to 2,342 children. In other words, the number of children under domestic instruction was nearly nine times the number of pupils in public schools. The average age of admission to a public elementary school was 8 years and the average age of leaving school was 14 years. The average pay of the teachers in elementary schools was Rs. 5-8 per month.

There were no indigenous colleges conducted by Muslims. But Adam found 38 Sanskrit colleges with 397 students. The average age of the admission was 11 years and the average age of completing the course was 27 years. Of the 397 students, 136 belonged to the villages where the colleges were situated and received free education only, while 261 students belonged to other villages and received food, lodging and education, free of charge, from their teachers.

Female education was practically non-existent. But Adam estimated that the total number of instructed adults in Nattore was 6,121 as follows:

¹ *Progress of Education*, July 1940, p. 38.

Teachers in Hindu Colleges	39
Learned men who were not teachers	88
Students in Colleges	397
Persons who had received an education superior to reading and writing	3,255
Persons who could sign their names or read imperfectly	2,342
TOTAL	6,121

This gives a literacy percentage of 6.1 to the total male population and 3.1 to the whole population including females.

(c) *Adam's Third Report*: The third report of Adam is the most important of all. It is divided into two parts. In the first part Adam gives the statistics collected by him for five districts, viz., Murshidabad, Birbhum, Burdwan, South Bihar and Tirhut. In the second part, he gives his proposals for the reform of indigenous schools.

Adam prefers his third report by admitting that, in spite of all that he could do, his statistics were underestimated. The causes are mainly two: In the first place, he conducted the investigation under his personal supervision in one Thana of each district and employed agents to collect information from the other Thanas. This enabled him to collect a good deal of data but he found that the reports of his agents were not quite reliable. "Although I believe", wrote Adam, "that the returns I receive are in general worthy of confidence as far as they go, yet I have no security that they are not defective. In traversing a district, my agents could not visit all the villages it contained, amounting to several thousands. This was physically impossible without protracting the enquiry beyond all reasonable limits. They were, therefore, compelled to depend either upon their personal knowledge, or upon the information that could be gathered from others as to the places possessing schools, every one of which was invariably visited and examined; but that in no instance a village-institution has been overlooked is more than I dare affirm, and in point of fact I have sometimes discovered instances in which such institutions had at first escaped attention."¹ Secondly, he found that

¹ *Adam's Reports*—Calcutta Edition, p. 219.

sometimes the people got frightened at the enquiry and concealed the exact number of females in the house, and that often, even schools and colleges "concealed themselves to escape the dreaded inquisition."¹ But even after making allowance for these candid confessions, it must be admitted that his statistics of indigenous education are the most reliable of all the statistics we possess on the subject.

The following tables summarise the general statistics given by Adam:

TABLE I—Schools

District	Number of schools								Total
	Bengali	Hindi	Sanskrit	Persian	Formal Arabic	Arabic	English	Girls	
Murshidabad	62	5	24	17	..	2	2	1	113
Birbhum	407	5	56	71	..	2	2	1	544
Burdwan	629+1 (infants)	..	190	93	3	8	3	4	931
South Bihar	..	286	27	279	..	12	1	..	605
Tirhut	..	80	56	234	..	4	..	..	374
Total	1,099	376	353	694	3	28	8	6	2,567

TABLE II—Scholars

District	Number of scholars					Total
	Bengali & Hindi	Sanskrit	Persian & Arabic	English	Girls	
Murshidabad	1,080	153	109	26	28	1,396
Birbhum	6,383	393	490	73	11	7,350
Burdwan	13,190	1,358	971	120	175	15,814
South Bihar	3,090	437	1,486	23	..	5,036
Tirhut	507	214	598	..	..	1,319
Total	24,250	2,555	3,654	242	214	30,915

¹ *Ibid.*, p. 220.

These statistics *exclude* the centres of domestic instruction and if reliance is to be placed on these alone, it is obvious that the report of one lakh schools in Bengal can only be a *myth*. This is exactly the argument used by Sir Philip Hartog who gives the following figures:

Area	Population	No. of schools actually existing	Hypothetical number of schools on the basis of one school per 400 of population
Murshidabad	186,841	113	467
Birbhum	1,267,067	544	3,168
Burdwan	1,187,580	931	2,969
South Bihar	1,340,610	605	3,352
Tirhut	1,697,700	374	4,244

(Taken from p. 83 of *Some Aspects of Indian Education*.)

Area	Popu- lation	No. of towns and villages	Number of schools				Total	No. of hypothetical schools on the basis of one school for 400 people
			Elementary schools (inclu- des Persian)	Schools of learning	Other schools	Private schools of domestic instruction		
City of Murshidabad	124,804	..	59	26	3	216	304	312
Thana Daulatbazar	62,037	183	5	..	..	254	279	155
„ Nanglia	46,416	267	34	2	..	207	243	116
„ Culna	116,425	288	79	38	2	475	594	291
„ Jehanabad	81,480	803	85	7	..	360	452	203
„ Bhawara	65,812	402	6	7	..	235	248	164
Total	496,974	1,943	288	80	5	1,747	2,120	1,241

Evidently, Adam could not but have noticed the great discrepancy between his earlier statement of the existence of one lakh schools in Bengal and these figures; and the only way in which one can explain his silence is to assume that he *knew* that centres of domestic instruction were excluded from these figures and that his earlier report would have been true if they had been included. For instance, **he collected the figures for centres of domestic instruction in one Thana of each of the above districts and his figures bear out his earlier statement in its entirety.**

Similarly, we shall have to take into consideration the number of children under domestic instruction if we want to have a correct idea of the population receiving instruction. The following statistics for the six Thanases where intensive studies were undertaken are supplied by Adam:

Area	Population	No. of children receiving school instruction	No. of children receiving domestic instruction	Total No. of children receiving domestic and school instruction
1	2	3	4	5
City of Murshidabad	124,804	959	300	1,259
Thana Daulatbazar	62,037	305	326	631
„ Nanglia	46,416	439	285	724
„ Culna	116,425	2,243	676	2,919
„ Jehanabad	81,480	366	539	905
„ Bhawara	65,812	60	288	348
Total	496,974	4,372	2,414	6,786

These figures show that the ratio of pupils to total population was 1 to 73. If male population alone is considered, the ratio would be 1 to 36, that is to say, a little less than the ratio given by Munro.

	City of Murshidabad	Thana Daulat- bazar	Thana Nanglia	Thana Culina	Thana Jehan- abad	Thana Bhawara	Total of last six columns
1. Adults who have received a learned education and are engaged in the business of teaching	33	..	2	38	6	7	86
2. Adults who have received a learned education and who are not engaged in the business of teaching	75	13	12	99	19	27	245
3. Adults who have not received a learned education and who are engaged in the business of teaching with attainments superior to a mere knowledge of reading and writing	60	25	34	93	53	6	271
4. Adults who have neither received a learned education nor are engaged in the business of teaching but who possess attainment superior to a mere knowledge of reading and writing	4,767	555	352	2,424	992	425	9,515
5. Adults who can merely read and write	1,700	614	593	2,304	761	303	6,275
6. Adults who can decipher or sign their names	715	565	620	2,350	1,004	265	5,519
Total	7,350	1,772	1,613	7,308	2,835	1,033	12,911

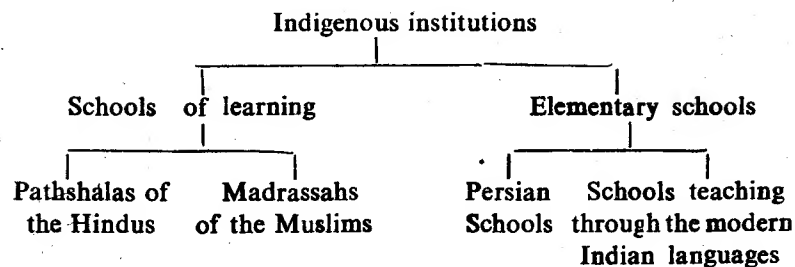
N.B.—This table is taken from *Literacy of India in Pre-British Days* by R. V. Parulekar.

Let us now turn to the statistics of literacy given by Adam (see Table on p. 22). They are equivalent to "the first systematic census of literacy in India".¹ But one aspect of these statistics is challenged by scholars like Sir Philip. Adam divided his adult literates into six classes under the sixth of which he enumerated all persons who could "decipher or sign their names". The census definition of literacy is "ability to read and write a letter" and judged from this point of view, these persons cannot be considered to be literate. In comparing Adam's figures of literacy with those of later days, therefore, Sir Philip excludes the 5,519 persons who could only "decipher or sign their names". This view, however, is challenged by other students of history like Shri R. V. Parulekar. He, and others who agree with him, contend that standards of attainment are bound to vary from age to age and that it would be wrong to judge Adam's age by standards which came to be adopted a century later. In his day, there were no papers, no printed books, no post-offices and hence the requirements of people in the matter of literacy were very limited indeed. They, therefore, argue that in comparing Adam's figures of literacy with those of later years, we must include all persons whom he himself regarded as literate. This point will be discussed in further detail in Chapter 8. It would, however, be enough to state here that the principal use of these statistics, viz., comparison with the statistics of literacy in British India in 1921 is not materially affected by the adoption of either view.

Extent and Character of the Indigenous System of Education at the Beginning of the Nineteenth Century: In the foregoing pages, we took a bird's-eye view of the principal sources of information regarding the indigenous system of education. We shall now conclude this discussion with a brief description of the character and extent of indigenous education as it existed at the beginning of the nineteenth century.

(a) **Types of Institutions:** The indigenous educational institutions of this period were divided into four main types as follows:

¹Sir Philip Hartog: *Some Aspects of Indian Education*, p. 84.



(b) *Schools of Learning*: Although the Hindus and Muslims had separate schools of learning, several important features were common to both the types of institutions. For instance, both kinds of institutions received pecuniary assistance from rulers, chieftains and opulent or religious citizens. Both were staffed by learned teachers, some of whom were authors of repute, but most of whom received very low remuneration. In both, instruction was mostly given gratis and no regular fees, as now understood, were charged. Both were mediaeval in character, used a classical language as the medium of instruction (Sanskrit in one case and Arabic or Persian in the other), and imparted instruction on traditional lines. In both, the teachers were remunerated in one or more of the following ways, viz., grants of land made by rulers, occasional voluntary parents from pupils and members of the public, allowances paid by wealthy citizens and payment in the form of food, clothes or other articles. Lastly, both had a few teachers who not only taught gratis but also provided food and lodging to their pupils.

Generally speaking, the schools had no special buildings of their own. Where these existed, they were built either by the teachers themselves, or at the expense of patrons or friends, or by subscriptions from the people. In most cases, however, the schools were held in the local temple or mosque and not infrequently in the house of some local magnate or patron or of the teacher himself. The students entered the schools at a fairly early age and studied as long as they desired and often for as long as twelve years or more. It must be noted that the State had nothing to do with the day-to-day work of these schools. They were conducted by learned men individually who did so more for religious

than for pecuniary considerations.

The Hindu schools of learning were conducted almost exclusively by Brahmins and a very large majority of the students attending them were Brahmins. There were no women students nor any persons belonging to the large number of communities who were denied the right to study the sacred lore. In the Persian and Arabic schools, on the other hand, though the teachers were generally Muslims, a Hindu teacher of Persian was not a rare phenomenon. Moreover, several Hindus attended Persian schools conducted by Muslims because Persian was then the Court language. In some of the Bengal districts, Adam even found that the majority of students in Persian schools were Hindus.

(c) *The Indigenous Elementary Schools*: The schools of learning of this period correspond to the colleges of modern type. They gave the highest instruction known, which, in those days, meant mostly religious instruction. Their chief object was to produce Moulavis and Pandits, and people were led to support them mainly by religious motives. Although they were highly venerated by the people, they were really the weaker and less useful part of the educational system on account of their exclusive character, conservative tone and obsolete ideals and methods of instruction.

The indigenous elementary school, the main agency for the spread of mass education, was a humbler but far more useful institution. The instruction given in it was of a practical type and mostly limited to the three R's. It catered, not to the needs of the priestly class, but to the mundane requirements of the petty zamindar, the bania and the well-to-do farmer. It had no religious veneration attached to it, and consequently, it had no endowments either from the State or from the public. Its teachers were men of ordinary attainments and, very often, they knew no more than the little they taught in their schools. Their remuneration was much lower than that of the teachers in the schools of learning and, except in those cases, where the teacher was maintained by a rich person, consisted of small collections or occasional presents from parents of children who attended the school. Occasionally, some of the teachers in these schools followed some other profession or trade for their maintenance and conducted the school only as a side business. Unlike the schools of learning, it is worthy of note that the pupils in these schools included a small

percentage of girls and children of many communities although the children of the upper classes formed the large majority.

Some features of the indigenous elementary schools are of great interest. For instance, **their equipment was extremely simple.** They had no buildings and were held, sometimes, in the house of the teacher or the patron of the school, **often in a local temple, and not infrequently under a tree.** There were no printed books and the slates or pencils used by pupils were such as could be easily made in the locality. The hours of instruction and the days of working were finely adjusted to local requirements. The size of the school was generally small—the **number of pupils varying from one or two to ten or fifteen at the most.** There were consequently no classes, no regular period of admission, etc. A pupil joined the school at any time, became a class by himself, followed his own pace of study, and left the school when he had acquired all that he desired to know or the school had to teach. In bigger schools, there was in vogue a system under which the senior pupils were appointed to teach junior ones. It was this system that attracted attention of Dr. Bell, the Presidency Chaplain at Madras, and which he introduced in England as a cheap and efficient method of educating the poor. The system later came to be known as the Monitorial or Madras system in England. The curriculum was very narrow and consisted of reading, writing, arithmetic (both written and oral) and accounts. There was no fee in the modern sense, but each parent who sent his child to the school generally made some payment to the teacher—either in cash or in kind. The amount of the payment depended upon the capacity of the parent and even the time and mode of payment were left to his convenience.

The chief merits of the indigenous system of elementary schools were their adaptability to local environment and the vitality and popularity they had earned by centuries of existence under a variety of economic conditions or political vicissitudes. Their main defects were the exclusion of girls and Harijan pupils. To these may be added (although such a judgment suffers from the defect of imposing modern concepts of education upon an earlier period) the lack of training or sound education among their teachers, their narrow and limited curriculum, and the severe forms of punishment adopted.¹

¹Calcutta Review, No. IV, p. 334

(d) *The Extent of Mass Education:* **It appears that schools, particularly centres of domestic instruction, abounded in every part of the country and that some humble means of instruction or other was available even in very small villages where, for years together, the British administration found it difficult to establish and maintain even a primary school.** The percentage of literacy was anything between 8 and 12 among the male adult population, or between 4 and 6 for the population as a whole. Certain of the higher castes were wholly literate in so far as the male adult population was concerned, while the women of all castes (with a very few individual exceptions) and the entire population of several lower castes were wholly illiterate.

(e) *Decaying Condition of Indigenous Education:* Another feature that emerges from the study of the sources is that, at the beginning of the nineteenth century, **the indigenous system of education was fast decaying on account of the prevailing anarchy or the growing impoverishment of the people under the British Rule.**¹

Potentialities of the Indigenous System of Education to Develop into a National System of Education by Suitable Extension and Improvement: The preceding discussion regarding the character and extent of the **indigenous system of education brings us to the final point, whether the system had potentialities which made it capable of being developed into a national system of education by suitable improvement and extension. In our opinion it certainly had these potentialities.** We are led to this conclusion by two general considerations. Firstly, we find that, in most countries of the world which are now educationally progressive the national system of education was built up on the foundations of the traditional system—in spite of its admitted and numerous defects. **In England, for instance, mass education was spread by gradual expansion and improvement of the defective voluntary schools which already existed.** A great authority like Sir Michael Sadler justifies the wisdom of this step and pays a tribute to their valuable contribution to the development of mass education in England. He says, "Although the teachers were, as a rule, not trained

¹Nurullah and Naik: *History of Education in India during the British Period*, pp. 42-43.

and often unable to impart knowledge, although the buildings were frequently not suitable for schools, the books deficient in numbers and quality, the attendance of the scholars very irregular, **yet the first step not only had been taken but the children had been accustomed to school life.**¹ What the voluntary school did to the cause of mass education in England, the indigenous schools could certainly have done to the cause of education in India as a whole, if only those in authority had seen their way to help them to live, expand and improve.

Secondly, our view is also supported by that of several British officers and workers. Adam, for instance, was thoroughly convinced that a national system of education could be build up in India on the foundation of the indigenous schools. He said:

To whatever extent such institutions may exist, and in whatever condition they may be found, stationary, advancing, or retrograding, **they present the only true and sure foundations on which any scheme of general or national education can be established.** We may deepen and extend the foundations; we may improve, enlarge and beautify the superstructure; but these are the foundations on which the building should be raised. All men, particularly uninstructed and half-instructed men, attach the same importance to forms as to substance, and as forms are merely conventional, it is desirable in the work of reform to disembarass ourselves of opposition founded on the overthrow of ancient forms, and to enlist on our side the prepossessions in favour of their continued use. Besides, there is a probability that those forms, if not at the period of their original adoption, yet by long continued usage are suited to the manners, habits, and general character of the people whom we desire to benefit, and that any other forms which we might seek to establish would in reality be less fitted to supply their place. All schemes for the improvement of education, therefore, to be efficient and permanent, should be based upon the existing institutions of the country, transmitted from time immemorial, familiar to the conceptions of the people and inspiring them with respect and veneration. **To labour successfully for them, we must labour with them; and to labour successfully with them,**

¹Special Reports on Educational Subjects, Vol. II, p. 449.

we must get them to labour willingly and intelligently with us. We must make them, in short, the instruments of their own improvement; and how can this be done but by identifying ourselves and our improvements with them and their institutions?¹

Adam, therefore, recommended that—

*existing native institutions from the highest to the lowest, of all kinds and classes, were the fittest means to be employed for raising and improving the character of the people, that to employ those institutions for such a purpose would be the simplest, the safest, the most popular, the most economical, and the most effectual plan for giving that stimulus to the native mind which it needs on the subject of education, and for eliciting the exertions of the natives themselves for their improvement, without which all other means must be unavailing. . . .*²

With these general observations Adam described the proposed working of his plan for the improvement of indigenous schools in the following seven stages:

- (a) The first step was to select one or more districts in which the plan could be tried as an experiment.
- (b) The second step was to hold a thorough educational survey of the district or districts selected more or less on the same lines on which he had conducted his investigations.
- (c) The third step was to prepare a set of books in modern Indian languages for the use of teachers and pupils.
- (d) The fourth step was to appoint an Examiner for each district as the chief executive officer of the plan. His duties would be to survey his area, to meet teachers, to explain the books, to conduct examinations, to grant rewards, and generally to be responsible for carrying out the plan successfully.
- (e) The fifth step was to distribute the books to teachers and stimulate them to study them by the holding of examina-

¹Adam's Reports, Calcutta Edition, pp. lviii-ix.

²Adam's Reports, Calcutta Edition, pp. 349-50.

tions and the granting of rewards to those who passed the tests. Adam also recommended the establishment of Normal schools where teachers of indigenous schools could be encouraged to study from one to three months a year for about four years so that their qualifications could be improved without inconveniencing their pupils.

- (f) The sixth step was to encourage the teachers to impart the newly acquired knowledge to their pupils by holding examinations for them and by granting rewards.
- (g) The seventh step was to grant endowments of lands to village schools in order to encourage teachers to settle down in villages and to educate the rural children. Adam pointed out several sources from which such gifts of land could be made or secured by Government.

Other plans for the development of the indigenous institutions were prepared or suggested by several administrators and educationists, such as Munro, Elphinstone, Thomason, Leitner, and were described in detail in several documents on educational policy such as the Despatch of 1854 or the Report of the Indian Education Commission, 1882-83. These will be dealt with in due course. But these proposals mostly went unheeded; the officials of the Education Department allowed the indigenous system to die and spent their time and energy in creating a new system of education, *ab initio*.

The modern educational system in India should have been built upon the foundations of the indigenous system, and the efforts of our educational administrators should have been directed to the improvement of these institutions and to their incorporation in the modern system of education. But this was never done. On the other hand, some attempts were made to encourage the schools of learning which were admittedly the weaker side of indigenous education, but even these were soon abandoned. The vast network of elementary schools never received the attention it deserved at the hands of Government. In spite of the exhortations of thinkers like Adam, Munro and Thomason, the directions of the Despatch of 1854 and the strong recommendations of the Indian Education Commission, indigen-

ous elementary schools were either killed by ill-planned attempts at reform, or destroyed by deliberate competition, or allowed to die of sheer neglect.

The results have been disastrous. It is true that attempts were made by the officers of the East India Company, and later by the Education Departments, to create a new system of education in India. For several reasons, the process was slow, and it could hardly compensate for the loss of the indigenous schools, with the result that the educational position of India in 1921 was hardly better than that in 1821. In the meanwhile, other nations of the East and West, whose educational advance was equal, or even inferior to that of India in 1821, made such rapid advances that India soon lost her position of vantage in the comity of nations and became one of the most educationally backward countries of the world!

The Monitorial System: Before we end this discussion of the indigenous educational system of India, we would like to point out with pride that the indigenous schools of India contributed the idea of the monitorial system to England. Historians talk only of England's contribution to Indian Education and they generally ignore the great contribution which was made by India to the spread of education among the poorer classes of England herself. Dr. Bell, the Presidency Chaplain at Madras, was the first Englishman to realise the value of the Indian system of teaching with the help of monitors—a system that prevailed extensively in the indigenous schools. Dr. Bell realised that the main advantage of the system was to enable the teacher to manage a large number of pupils at a time so that the spread of education could be effected at a very low cost. He, therefore, advocated the adoption of this system in England in a book entitled *An Experiment in Education made at the Male Asylum at Madras, suggesting a system by which a school or a Family may teach itself under the superintendence of the Master or Parent* (1798). This book attracted great attention and eventually the Indian system was almost universally adopted in England. This system, variously described as the Madras system, or the Monitorial system, was the chief method by which England achieved expansion of primary education at a very low cost between 1801 and

1845. It is an irony of fate that the indigenous schools of India should thus contribute to the spread of education in England and be of no avail in spreading mass education in India herself!

CHAPTER TWO

The East India Company Accepts Responsibility for the Education of Indians

(1600-1813)

Proselytizing and Educational Activities of the East India Company (1600-1765): The East India Company was, in this period, a primarily commercial concern and it is, therefore, not proper to expect it to take any steps for the education of the Indian people. But N. N. Law points out that, even in these early years, the Company was engaged in fostering some proselytizing and educational activities within its possessions. As early as in 1614, steps were taken "for the recruitment of Indians for the propagation of the Gospel among their countrymen and for imparting to these missionaries such education, at the Company's expense, as would enable them to carry out effectively the purposes for which they were enlisted".¹ It is also on record that an Indian youth, christened *Peter* by King James I, was taken to England for education in the Christian doctrine although what he did later on is not known.² In 1659, the Court of Directors explicitly stated that it was their earnest desire by all possible means to spread Christianity among the people of India and allowed missionaries to embark on their ships.³ This evangelical zeal found support in contemporary England where the Church was experiencing the revival of a deep religious fervour so that, when the Charter of the Company was renewed in 1698, the famous *missionary clause* was inserted in it by Parliament. This clause directed the Company to maintain ministers of religion at their factories in India and to take a

¹N. N. Law: *Promotion of Learning in India by Early European Settlers*, pp. 7-8.

²*Ibid.*, p. 7.

³W. H. Sharp: *Selections from Educational Records*, Vol I, p. 3.